



MAYA

PRESERVING THE PAST

THE ANCIENT MAYA HAD ONE OF THE MOST SOPHISTICATED civilizations that ever existed. As well as a practical calendar, a written history, an intricate system of mathematics, and a complex rule of law, they had a hugely impressive arts and crafts tradition. But, by the 10th

The modern way

About six million Maya live in Central America. Like their ancestors, many of them survive by growing maize (Indian corn) or other crops on their land, or by producing woven textiles for sale. In some villages, the men have to leave their families to find work in the cities, or on coffee and cotton plantations in other areas.

Some Mayan textile designs are hundreds of years old.



FEEDING THE FAMILY

Maize is an essential crop for the Mayan people, and it forms a major part of their diet. This busy mother uses ground maize to make *tortillas* (pancakes) over a wood fire, but it can also be served baked, boiled, and made into bread. Supplementing this basic fare are other vegetables (like beans and squash), fruit, and small amounts of meat and fish.

LIVING LEGENDS

Formed by a group of writers, and based in Chiapas in Mexico, the *Sna Jtz'ibajom* theater company brings Mayan myths, legends, and history to life through elaborate plays and puppet shows that tour widely. Their name, *Sna Jtz'ibajom*, means "The House of the Writer."

